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She provides answers to questions on the questions

Rising social media star praised for her nuance

By Aidan Ryan
GLOBE STAFF

The online debate over a ballot question that would scrap Massachusetts' long-held partisan primary election system has gotten pretty personal.

Opponents of the measure, noting that much of its financial backing is from private equity executives, have branded supporters as shills for "oligarchs" who want to "buy elections."

Supporters, meanwhile, argue that anyone working to keep the current system in place must be a tool of the political establishment.

So it might be surprising that the breakout social media star of the campaign — and other debates surrounding the complicated ballot questions appearing before voters on Tuesday — is a sober-minded thirtysomething on the South Shore posting explanatory videos with nary an ad-hominem to be found.

Sarah Whitman, a Massachusetts native who works for the Boston restaurant-tech company Toast, has in her spare time racked up nearly 1.5 million views on TikTok and Instagram, outpacing many well-funded campaigns surrounding the nine ballot questions. Her recipe of low-production, conversational videos has resonated with people struggling to navigate the highly technical nature of the issues.

Whitman, who has shared her views on political news for years and in the past few

QUESTIONS, Page A6

Prosecution's expert says evidence shows Birchmore slain

By Laura Crimaldi and Sean Cotter
GLOBE STAFF

The hyoid bone in Sandra Birchmore's neck was broken, an unusual injury for a purported suicide of a young person. She had scuff marks on her face. And, perhaps most strikingly to Dr. William Smock, her hair was tangled in the duffel-bag strap from which she was found hanging.

To Smock, the findings were clear.

"This is an altered crime scene," Smock, an independent medical expert who has studied strangulation and coverups, testified Tuesday in the federal trial of Matthew Farwell in Birchmore's death.

"This was a homicide."

Smock's testimony came as the prosecution approached the end of its case in Farwell's high-profile murder trial.

It punctuated a dramatic day in federal court that also included testimony from Farwell's fraternal twin brother, William, a fellow former Stoughton police officer and romantic partner of Birchmore's; he testified under the protection of immunity as he told the jury about what he saw before and after Birchmore died.

Matthew Farwell is accused of strangling a pregnant Birchmore on Feb. 1, 2021, and staging her death to look like a suicide in an

TRIAL, Page A10

So far, little interference with voting

Concerns remain about what Trump might do afterward

By Jim Puzzanghera
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — As time dwindles before Election Day, so do opportunities for the extensive interference that many Democrats and voting rights advocates have feared from President Trump in the run-up to the pivotal midterms.

But experts warn the elections are not nearly out of the woods yet.

So far, four doomsday scenarios based on Trump's statements and actions have yet to materialize, in part because of legal challenges against aggressive attempts by his administration to restrict voting. There has been no major purge of voter rolls, no widespread failure to deliver mail ballots, no major presence of Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers at early voting locations, and no national emergency declaration that could suppress or even halt voting.

"We look at every potential situation that could arise, and so far it's just been really a smooth, quiet election . . . and early voting is going strong," said Georgia Secretary of State Brad Raffensperger, a Republican, noting that elections officials nationwide are in communication. "We're all sharing best practices and making sure that we're on our toes, ready for anything that could happen during that 12-hour period when the polls are open on Election Day."

But even as more than 34 million people already have cast their ballots, according to the Election Lab at the University of Florida, state officials still must get through the surge of voters on Election Day and count all the ballots. Then comes the certification of winners and their official seating, both of which the Trump administration and its allies could try to block.

Charles Stewart III, director of the MIT Election Data and Science Lab, published an academic paper in September outlining the threats and

ELECTION SECURITY, Page A6

'It seems like everything is up. It wasn't always this hard.'

KELSON THOMAS, *a marine engineer*



JONATHAN WIGGS/GLOBE STAFF

Jose DeSilva has been busy at Boston Firewood in Hyde Park. Some places are scrambling to keep up with orders.

AS HEATING OIL GOES UP, THERMOSTATS GO DOWN

Dealing with soaring costs means wear more layers and load up on firewood

By Shannon Larson
GLOBE STAFF

Each fall, Jon Strauss locks in heating oil pricing for his North Andover home so he knows how much it'll cost to fill the tank during the colder months.

Last winter, he spent close to $2,000 for fuel, but this year it's anyone's guess.

Heating oil prices have soared, and his supplier isn't offering price lock deals with the market so volatile. To cut costs, Strauss plans to keep the thermostat low and rely more on space heaters. He just picked up four.

"That's our plan of attack as of now," said Strauss, 50, a transportation engineer. "I'm legitimately concerned that there's going to be a lot of people in New England who are going to get financially devastated this winter."

It's been a familiar theme in recent years, but this season may be the most expensive yet. Last week, the retail price of heating oil was averaging $6.23 a gallon in Massachusetts — up a stunning 75 percent from a year ago. Electricity costs have also skyrocketed, with residents here now paying about 40 percent more for power than they did five years ago, according to data from the US Chamber of Commerce. And natural gas prices? Also surging in recent years. The sky-high energy costs, coupled with rising prices for so many other goods, are stretching many household budgets to the limit.

So Massachusetts residents are searching for ways to keep their homes warm without breaking the bank.

Mary Thomas, 48, said she felt a mix of anger and concern when she paid nearly $760 for a recent oil tank fill-up, "significantly more" than last year.

A social worker who lives in Stoneham, Thomas said she's aiming to reduce her oil use by sealing windows, installing door draft stoppers, and hanging tapestries on walls for added insulation, like people did in medieval times. She also plans to lean on her wood stove, even though bags of pellets have more than doubled in cost since last year — climb-

HEATING OIL, Page A7

Spirits you won't find on any bar menu



JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

Hecate bartenders Vikki Aubin (left) and Molly Bird listened as medium Tiffany Rice gave a reading.

By Devra First
GLOBE STAFF

Are Boston's restaurants haunted?

This old city is said to be home to plenty of ghosts — from author Charles Dickens, haunting the floor he stayed on at the Omni Parker hotel, to Fort Warren specter the Lady in Black. Many of our restaurants are located in antique buildings where power brokers brokered, criminals consorted, and history played out. Why *wouldn't* they be haunted?

With Halloween approaching, it seems as good a time as any to investigate. So, on a sunny Thursday, I head out on the town with psychic and spirit medium Tiffany Rice, just back from touring in Vegas. We are going to try to find the ghosts of dinners past — and, hopefully, hear what they have to say.

First stop: South Boston restaurant Fox & the Knife, where Rice and I meet up (she is aware of some of our destinations in advance). Long before chef-owner Karen Akunowicz began serving taleggio-stuffed focaccia and house-made pasta here, the West Broadway spot was the bar Triple O's,

RESTAURANT GHOSTS, Page A7

Israeli voters apparently delivered a sharp rebuke to Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, but exit polls Wednesday suggested the election had no clear winner. **A3.**

For the second time this year, Harvard University graduate students walked off the job in an effort to pressure the university for a new contract. **B1.**

With it being notoriously difficult to open a restaurant in Boston, Mayor Michelle Wu's administration proposed tweaks to the zoning code that could make things easier. **B5.**

CDC deputy director Dr. Jennifer Shuford is leaving the agency months after being appointed by President Trump. **A3.**

Pumpkin it up

Wednesday: Seasonable. High 53-58. Low 45-50.

Thursday: Warming up again. High 65-70. Low 53-58.

Sunrise: 7:12 Sunset: 5:43

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

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